support for Sikh extremists have fuelled Indian press and parliamentary speculation of US complicity. We believe Soviet disinformation [on an increase] in extremist activity would prompt fresh accusations of foreign intervention in Punjab to deflect domestic criticism. Even if Gandhi discounted allegations of US involvement, pressure from his Hindu constituency, in the face of increased extremist activity, would probably force him to slow improvement in Indo-US relations. Unless Pakistani aid to Sikh extremists increases significantly, New Delhi is unlikely to seek Washington's aid in pressing Islamabad.

Many R&AW spies today are genuinely surprised to discover that the CIA became interested in Punjab as early as the mid-1960s and that its agents had begun forwarding intelligence reports to Washington on Sant Fateh Singh, the most influential Sikh leader of the time, who insisted that New Delhi should either make Punjabi the sole official language of Punjab or create a separate Punjabi-speaking state. CIA operatives on the ground predicted that efforts to find a solution were not necessarily doomed to failure, but great ingenuity would be required and time was running out for the Indian government.

Mathur later told me that the Americans did not intervene much in the activities of the Sikh militants inside the USA until they were provided with evidence and pressured to take concrete steps against the financiers and ring leaders of the separatist movement.

Political Challenges

Back home, the Indian government was fighting a psychological battle to win the hearts and minds of Punjab youth. Unfortunately, this battle wasn't free from the political games